'world steering committee' because they too will play by the basic rules. BRICS countries account for 42% of the world's population, 18% of its GDP, 15% of world trade and 40% of its currency reserves. (It is often ignored that the states comprising the Gulf Cooperation Council, namely Oman, UAE, Bahrain, Qatar, Kuwait and Saudi Arabia, which are all politically subordinate to the US and more obedient towards its economic needs, have in total more dollar reserves – official, sovereign wealth and other government funds – than does China.)

The main importance of BRICS lies in the fact that it accounts for more than half of the world's GDP growth rate. But there is no indication that there will be a real challenge to the neoliberal order and no interest in promoting an NIEO (New International Economic Order) of the kind that was once discussed by the Non-Aligned Movement (NAM) during the 1970s. Indeed, neither Brazil, which has observer status in the NAM, nor China, which achieved this in 1992, has shown interest in becoming full members of the NAM or in reinvigorating it as a mechanism for transforming global governance. Whether it is being part of the G20 or being aspirants to permanent status in the UN Security Council for those who are not yet permanent, or playing a bigger role in the WTO's Green Room decision-making, the emerging powers have shown more interest in joining the 'big boys' club'. They use their membership of the G77 and similar larger groups to project themselves as representatives of the interests of the majority of the poorer developing countries, the better to leverage pursuit of their national interests in negotiations within that club. This is a balancing act of sorts but not one whose primary purpose is to strengthen the South as a whole or prioritise the interests of the most vulnerable and poorest member countries within the South.

The reality is that a basic political-economic incompatibility rather than organisational handicaps limits the collective's capacity to function as a powerful and innovative new force in the realm of global politics and governance. The South African super-wealthy, mostly white, park much of their wealth and investments in Europe and Australia, creating a domestic balance of payments problem because of repatriation of profits and dividends to parent companies set up abroad. Given this powerful elite force, until 2013 when it crashed, South Africa maintained a strong rand, unlike the other four who are nowhere near as committed to maintaining a strong real, rouble, renminbi or rupee (Gentle 2012).

By demography (50 million) and total GDP, South Africa might not be in the same league as the other four or even as significant as Mexico, South Korea, or Turkey, but it is far and away the biggest investor in Africa, dwarfing the US, EU, China, India and Brazil, and it alone accounts for 40% of all African investment and 80% of all investments in the Southern African Development Community